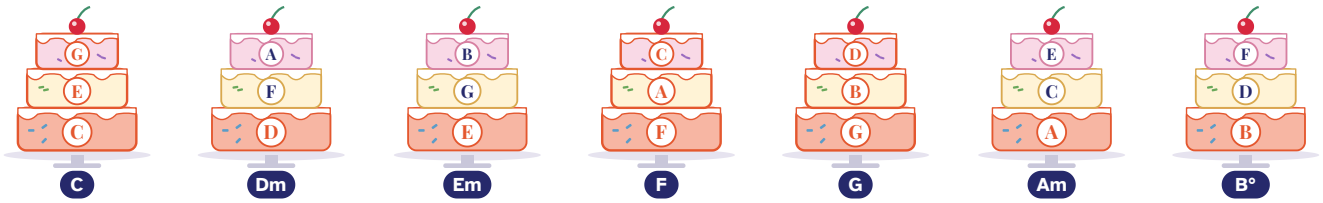
PART IV · CHORDS · 3

# Chords in a key

Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

**THE SECRET**

**Build a cake on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.**




*One cake on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work*




The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 90.

| NUMERAL | NAME | KIND | KEYS BETWEEN | IN C | IN G |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **I** | tonic | major | 3 + 2 | C | G |
| ii | supertonic | minor | 2 + 3 | Dm | Am |
| iii | mediant | minor | 2 + 3 | Em | Bm |
| **IV** | subdominant | major | 3 + 2 | F | C |
| **V** | dominant | major | 3 + 2 | G | D |
| vi | submediant | minor | 2 + 3 | Am | Em |
| vii° | leading note | diminished | 2 + 2 | B° | F♯° |

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Levels 1–2; the other chords from about Level 4.

## The three primary chords

**I, IV and V** are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

**THINK OF IT** I is the key's own chord. IV and V are its two big neighbours. Between the three of them, every note of the scale has a chord to sit in.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

## In a minor key

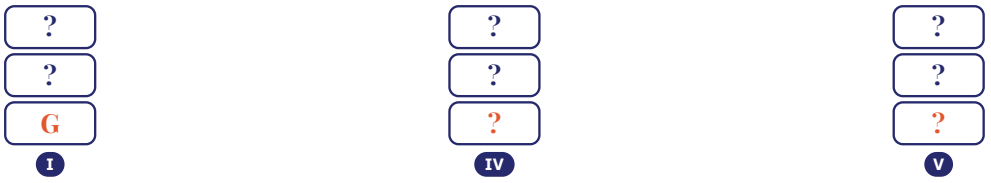
In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th** of the harmonic minor (p. 72), G♯. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.




A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

EXAMPLE 1

### Find I, IV and V in G major




1. **Count up the scale** from G: which notes are 1st, 4th and 5th?
2. **Build a cake on each,** using the key signature (one sharp: F♯).
3. **Check the keys between:** are all three 3 + 2?

In G major: **I = G** (G B D), **IV = C** (C E G), **V = D** (D F♯ A), all major.

GAME

### Which numeral?

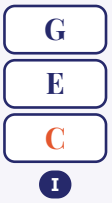



1 2 3 4

All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



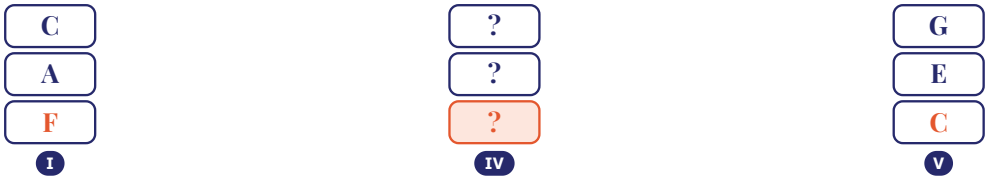

### Left hand: C, F, G.

Play the cakes of I, IV and V in C major, then sing any nursery tune over them: these three fit almost every note.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

### Find IV in F major




1. **Count up the scale** from F to the 4th note. Watch the key signature: one flat.
2. **Build the cake** on that note.
3. **Check the keys between.**

IV in F major is **B♭**: B♭ D F, 3 + 2, major.

EXAMPLE 3

### Find V in D minor




1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A: build A C E.
2. **The 7th note** of the D minor scale is C. In the harmonic minor it is raised: to what?
3. **Put it in the middle layer.** What kind is the chord now?

C becomes **C♯**: V in D minor is A C♯ E, **A major**.

EXAMPLE 4

### The chord on note 6 of C major




1. **Build the cake on A:** skip one, take the next, twice.
2. **Count the keys between:** major or minor?
3. **Note 6 of the scale:** which numeral, capital or small?

A C E, 2 + 3: **A minor**, numeral **vi** (small, because it is minor).

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 89 · Major scales p. 69 · Inversions p. 95

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 3 · Online: Library › Chords